

Francis Petts, Cannon Fire and the Complication of 115 Queen Street

Author: Michiko Quinones
Published: September 8, 2024

Main Content

The article explores the life of Francis Petts (also documented as Peates and Peets), a Black property owner at 115 Queen Street in Philadelphia during the 1830s-1840s. Petts purchased the home in 1837 and retained it until his death in 1851. The 1838 Pennsylvania Abolition Society census recorded Petts, his wife, and a child at the address, though the full census entry lists 22 other residents—approximately 25 people total across five family groups.

The property contained "a main house facing Queen Street and three smaller townhomes sharing a courtyard." Most residents were Pennsylvania-born, though five individuals had out-of-state origins and may have been freedom seekers. Four children attended school while five did not. Residents primarily worshipped at Bethel, with one family at Wesley and the Petts family at St. Thomas.

Documented Life and Economic Connections

Petts maintained extensive documentation. He served as a Vestryman at St. Thomas Church (1834-1835), held Masonic membership, and his funeral received notices in both the Public Ledger and from his lodge at the Philadelphia Institute. His will provides evidence of circulation within Black economic networks, including payments from beneficial societies (Sons of St. Thomas and Benezet Society), tenant payments from properties on Queen and Gaskill Streets, and payments to Black business owners including undertaker Francis Duterte, layer-of-the-dead Sarah Ash, and Jacob C. White for cemetery services. White abolitionist William Rawle, first president of the Historical Society of Pennsylvania, served as his lawyer.

Challenging Class Assumptions

Petts' location in Southwark contradicts historical assumptions about Black wealth concentration. While wealthy Black Philadelphians typically clustered around Lombard and Pine Streets (2nd to Broad), Petts lived among people of varied economic circumstances—creating "a small community of Black families" in closer proximity than elite counterparts like James Forten experienced. This spatial arrangement suggests more moderate lifestyles among Black elites than previously understood.

Tragedy and Violence

Petts' son, Francis Peets Jr., died of tuberculosis on August 12, 1842—ten days after the 1842 mob attacks targeting the Black community. The son was buried at Bethel Burying Ground, three blocks from the family home, rather than at the family's church cemetery. Historians question whether "St. Thomas' burial ground was not capable of holding a service during those times" or whether parents preferred proximity to monitor their son's grave.

This family trauma likely resurfaced in early July 1844 when "St. Phillip Neri church, directly across from the Petts' home was the scene of one of the most intense gun battles in Philadelphia's history." The Nativist Riots pitted white Protestant "natives" against Irish Catholic immigrants. Military forces deployed cannons, resulting in extensive casualties. The riots directly addressed the municipality's decade-long tolerance of violence against the Black community—a lack of response that "helped to open the door" for subsequent interethnic violence.

The fighting produced "seven fatalities and nine injuries" initially, with "fierce fighting" lasting "several hours" as "soldiers brought in two cannons" and mobs "returned fire using their own cannons, armed with items such as nails, chains, knives and broken bottles."

Spatial Complexity

By 1844, 115 Queen Street occupied a symbolically charged location: "the white protestant episcopal graveyard was directly to the east...and the Black protestant Bethel Burying ground directly to the west." St. Phillip Neri church stood directly opposite. This arrangement created what the author describes as "a metaphorically and energetically complicated space" where the Petts family "re-experience[d] the same spatial instability that surrounded the death of their son."

Locating the Property

Petts' deeds appear in Philadelphia deed records under variations of his name. After his death, Charles Beck appears at addresses 115 and 117 Queen. Following the 1854 Consolidation, the properties were renumbered as 233-237 Queen Street.

The building remains standing.

Images

- AI Imagining of Francis Petts — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_d18de2baa4fb41e2a7181840ebbecea9~mv2.png
- Excerpt from Volume 2, Page 35, 1838 PAS Census — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_f64a245a32bf4223a30cb96e2d034366~mv2.png
- The courtyard of 115 Queen — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_1ebd80dc74b14aa6921257faf19f130c~mv2.jpeg
- St Phillip Neri Church — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_44215560ef8e43eebc3843312de3e291~mv2.jpeg
- AI image of a child in 115 Queen on July 8, 1844 — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/f61430_c6e7756f6a124b719c9ccd16a4cb38ea~mv2.jpg
- Aftermath view of Queen Street — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_280baf52135a4472a77a4eb58f362d5f~mv2.jpg
- Francis Petts' signature from his will — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_cb4259c664bd4e16b71f349102f79293~mv2.png
- Detail from Francis Petts' will (deed reference) — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_f2f10e36400b44d88df3554acdb9b8cd~mv2.jpg
- Detail from City Directories — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_9660221c133e4ddda89f7940e9774aca~mv2.jpg

WORDCOUNT: 1,050